

Notice concerning Jacobi's scientific estate

Translated from the German

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Soon after Jacobi's lamented death, Frau Professor Jacobi, with a trust that honored me, placed in my hands the whole scientific estate of my unforgettable friend. In order first to obtain a general overview of it, it was necessary to arrange the great mathematician's numerous manuscripts by subject. This task, which I undertook jointly with Jacobi's friends here, Messrs. Borchardt and Joachimsthal, was not without difficulty, since the manuscripts, probably as a consequence of repeated changes of residence, were in great disorder, and the separate quires or leaves that belonged together, usually without pagination, often had to be laboriously sought out from different bundles. As soon as this preliminary work is completed, in the execution of which we have been assisted by Messrs. Kummer and Rosenhain, who are presently here, the manuscripts are to be distributed among the friends of the deceased who have declared themselves ready for this, for the purpose of a detailed examination.

In the preliminary arrangement it has been found that only little is completely ready for print. In most cases there are repeated treatments of the same or closely related subjects, which evidently, although every indication of date is lacking in the manuscripts, belong to very different times. These treatments will have to be reviewed and compared with the greatest care, in order to determine which of the earlier ones have become superfluous through the later ones, or what is to be taken from the former and inserted at a suitable place in the later, so that nothing essential of the creations of the great, indefatigable investigator may be lost to science. The papers suitable for publication will be printed in the present journal, in which, with the exception of the two special works *Fundamenta nova theoriae functionum ellipticarum* and *Canon arithmeticus*, almost all of Jacobi's works first appeared, and are later to be collected, as he himself had already begun to do by publishing the first volume of his works (Berlin, G. Reimer, 1846).

Besides publishing the papers written by Jacobi himself, his friends intend to bring before the public the most important of the university lectures that he gave in Königsberg and here. To all who take an interest in the progress of the mathematical sciences it is known what influence Jacobi exerted, also in his vocation as a university teacher, to which he always devoted himself with special love and with the rarest success, on the great upswing that mathematical studies have taken during the last quarter century in our German fatherland. If the knowledge of higher analysis is now spread among us to a degree as at no earlier time, and if numerous younger mathematicians are extending and enriching the science in the most diverse directions, then he has had the greatest share in so gratifying a phenomenon. Almost all have been his pupils; rarely did a budding talent escape his attention, and no one, once he had recognized it, lacked his furthering counsel and encouraging participation.

So that such a successful teaching activity, to which death set so early a limit, may at least retain the after-effect which the printed word, in the absence of the living spoken word, is able to produce, the friends of the deceased will publish in print his most important lectures in exact reproduction. They are convinced that no more effective means of education can be placed in

the hands of the younger followers of science than the lectures of a creative mind who had made it his particular task, in all difficult investigations, to introduce his hearers into the course of thought of discovery.

Since Jacobi always delivered his lectures quite freely and without using a written draft, his estate contains, apart from a few brief notes, nothing in his own hand relating to his lectures. On the other hand, there are found in it very accurate transcripts of his most important lectures, made by several of his most distinguished hearers, which he had carefully collected for years, partly in order later to facilitate thereby the preparation of his lectures, and partly to use them in the preparation of textbooks which he intended to publish. With the help of these transcripts and others of equal accuracy that have been put at their disposal for this purpose, Jacobi's friends will be able to reproduce his most important lectures with great fidelity. Among these lectures, which will appear in individual volumes, the following may preliminarily be named: 1. those on the theory of elliptic functions; 2. those on the division of the circle and its applications to number theory; 3. those on analytic mechanics; and finally 4. those on the general theory of curves and surfaces. For some others of smaller scope, the decision whether they are to be printed remains reserved.

Berlin, August 1851.